He Made His Bricks Twice as Thick — voice-over

Read at about 170 words per minute (~60 s). Pause briefly at each comma, a beat at each full stop. Measham = "MEE-shum". Wilkes' gobs = "WILKS-iz gobs".

hook

He made his bricks twice as thick, because the tax man counted bricks.

war

In seventeen eighty-four, Britain needed money to pay for its war in America.

tax

Parliament put a tax on every single brick, two shillings and sixpence per thousand.

count

Officers walked into the brickyards and counted the wet bricks, row by row, before firing.

climb

And the price kept climbing, to four shillings per thousand by seventeen ninety-four.

but

But the law only counted bricks. It never said how big a brick could be.

yousee

You see, it's like paying for pizza by the slice. Cut bigger slices, and you pay for fewer.

wilkes

In Measham, brickmaker Joseph Wilkes made bricks about twice as thick as normal.

gobs

They became known as Wilkes' gobs, and a wall needed far fewer of them.

then

Then the government struck back. Any brick bigger than ten by five by three inches paid double.

so

So brickmakers shrank their moulds again, and the giant bricks stopped.

close

The tax lasted until eighteen fifty. But some of Wilkes' giant bricks are still standing today.